> "WHEN THE TOURNAMENT WAS IN PROGRESS KNIGHTS ... FELL IN SUCH NUMBERS, SOME DEAD, SOME PERMANENTLY DISABLED, THAT IT SEEMED THE SPORT NOT SO MUCH OF MEN AS OF DEMONS."
>
> **THOMAS OF CANTIMPRÉ** DESCRIBING A TOURNAMENT AT NEUSS, 1241

dedicated to following a monastic rule – or secular like the Order of the Golden Fleece in Burgundy, the Order of the Star in France, or the Order of the Band in Castile. But knights were not always so lofty in their pretensions. Others became outright mercenaries, leading "free companies" that were in effect private professional armies, selling their services to cities and states, none of which could afford to maintain permanent standing armies. Thus the force that a medieval king led off to war would be far from homogenous. It might include his own household knights, his barons or lords and their feudal followers, contingents provided by the military orders, and mercenaries led by their own chiefs.

At worst, during times of disorder and social breakdown, knights might degenerate into brigands, using their skills to carve out a dishonest living through robbery, plunder, and pillage.



Jousting helm
This late 15th-century German helmet features sloping sides to deflect an opponent's lance and steel attachments to lock the helm to the body armour.

TOURNAMENTS

Once the warrior caste of knights had been created, they needed a constant supply of pretexts for fighting, so they could fulfil their ambitious pursuit of glory and profit. There were normally wars to be found, if not in a knight's home country then around the periphery of the Christian world where crusades were more or less permanently in progress against Muslims or pagans. But an outlet for martial energies and ambitions was also to be found in the tournaments that became popular throughout Western Europe from the 12th century onward. Although these did function as practical military training exercises, they were primarily sport – a source of competitive fun but also a public arena in which talented combatants could seek fame and fortune.

Initially tournaments were the occasion of mock battles fought between two sides ranging over a wide area of countryside. As in real battles, knights were often taken prisoner, forfeiting their horse and equipment to their captor – a valuable prize. Deaths and serious injuries were common, with over 60 knights reportedly killed in one exceptionally costly tournament at Neuss in 1241. A substantial amount of damage was also done to property in the combat zone. By the 14th century, these hugely destructive free-for-alls had largely been replaced by strictly formalized combat fought with blunted weapons and under strictly enforced rules. Jousting became a central feature of tournaments in which individual knights charged one another with couched lance and completing their duel with swords on foot. Under the influence of chivalric romance, knights fought as the champions of ladies, whose tokens they wore. Participation in the jousts was vetted by heralds, who rejected from competition any candidates deemed not to be true knights. The adoption of special tournament armour, heavier than that worn for war, further reduced the risk of serious casualties. Whereas in the 13th century, tournaments had often been denounced as a futile waste of life, by the 15th century they were being lampooned as gutless displays of vanity.

MAKING WAR

Medieval knights were committed to an ideal of warfare in which mounted warriors fought one another at close quarters in a fair contest of courage, strength, and skill. But the reality of warfare was often very different.



Jousting tournament
The pomp and pageantry of the later medieval tournament is well captured in this scene from a 15th-century edition of Froissart's *Chronicles*.